

VIA NOVA

Dear Friends and Family,

This spring, I decided to join a Catholic apostolate called Via Nova. Via Nova provides "a new way" of equipping college aged Catholics for a life of freedom and mission." The core pillars of Via Nova are study, work, and prayer. I chose to join Via Nova, or Via for short, because I was looking for a deep, rich, formative spiritual and intellectual experience that I hadn't received before.

The discernment process for me was difficult due to the cultural and social pressures around me such as finishing my college education and entering the workforce as soon as possible. These factors, while having some merit, seemed futile compared to my reasons for wanting to join Via Nova.

My decision to join Via was largely influenced by my desires that were being formed in prayer. St. Francis de Sales says in his *Treatise on the Love of God*, "When God gives us faith he enters into our soul and speaks to our spirit, not by manner of discourse, but by way of inspiration, proposing in so sweet a manner unto the understanding that which ought to be believed, that the will receives therefrom a great complacency, so great indeed that it moves the understanding to consent and yield to truth without any doubt or distrust, and here lies the marvel: for God proposes the mysteries of faith to our souls amidst obscurities and darkness, in such sort that we do not see the truths but we only half-see them." What Francis is saying here is that when we have faith in God, our souls can better forfeit our desires, and the soul is more prone to receive the inspiration of wisdom that God gives us. This wisdom is not hearing words or thoughts coming from God, but it is an understanding that consents and yields to truths that are presented to us.

Before I detail my experience in Via Nova I will discuss the structures, routine, and rules that accompany this formative experience. Via Nova is a Catholic faith formation program for college-aged students. There are two separate Via houses, a men's house and a women's house. There are rules in the guys house that focus on creating a productive, spiritually-focused environment. Each of the guys has different responsibilities around the house each week, and we also restrict ourselves from going on tech in certain areas of the house such as bedrooms. The Fellows eat breakfast and have regular communal meals together. Each night we chant night prayer, which is a liturgical prayer practice that has its roots dating back as early as the 4th century. After night prayer, the Fellows enter a period of silence, free from tech and distractions. This helps maintain consistent sleep and also creates a peaceful environment for reflection, prayer, and reading. We also spend at least an hour in prayer each day and attend daily Mass together. These commitments help us break bad habits and maintain an ordered life. Going forward, I will describe my experience by exploring the three core structures that are central to Via Nova, namely study, work, and prayer.



The Via cohort at the end of year retreat

Study

The first core structure aims to develop the Fellow's intellectual faculties. This primarily consists of seminars on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays, for a total of 10 hours in seminar each week. The open discussion format of our seminars has improved my reasoning skills by listening to others' ideas, and articulating my own. The seminar content includes ancient Greek writings, such as the *Iliad*, the *Odyssey* and the *Nicomachean Ethics* by Homer and Aristotle, respectively. Our tutor, Mr. John Lindsley, helped us explore biblical narratives and various teachings of the Church. Mr. John previously taught philosophy at the Catholic University of America as an ardent atheist, but after a radical conversion, is now a devout Catholic. His wisdom has been invaluable in our seminars.



A seminar session with our tutor, Mr. John Lindsley



A Via presentation night

Furthering my intellectual growth was putting together two presentations this spring where we study a particular idea from our seminars that we wish to present to the wider community, and in turn deepen our own knowledge of the material. After our drafts are complete, we host “Presentation Nights” where we present to an audience. After presenting, we conclude with a question and answer period that refines the Fellow’s knowledge of the material. In my first presentation, I explored the differences between pagan and Christian piety using the *Odyssey*. The process of searching for themes and ideas to construct an argument strengthened my knowledge of the text, improved my analytical skills, and gave me a comprehensive perspective of the central ideas and themes in the epic.

Each work that we have read has had a different impact on me. The *Iliad* was the first book we read in the spring, and being that it was one of the oldest literary works on Earth, it seemed like a daunting task. But as I continued to read through The *Iliad*, my comprehension of the text increased, and I felt as if my reading skills had improved. The epic told the story of the Trojan War and how Achilles’ festering anger slowly grew to the point of no return, finally unleashing his anger against the Trojans, propelling the Greeks to win the war. A major theme of the *Iliad* was the nature of the gods. These gods revealed the despairing conception of the Gods that the ancient Greeks held, which was that one: the gods are imperfect and sometimes evil; two: they do not care about mortals and use their lives as tools for entertainment; and three: their power cannot even explain fate, which has power over them. These three conceptions of divine nature starkly contrast with the Christian worldview that our God is all perfect, good, personal, and has power over all things.

The ancient Greek worldview held in the Homeric narratives revealed valuable historical context that contributed to many pre-Christian ideologies that shaped much of western society today. Comparing the ancient Greek religious worldview to the Christian worldview helps reveal how fortunate we are to have an all good, knowing, and powerful God who wants union with us. Christ reveals that our God constitutes everything that is good, and that we have an opportunity to be in eternal union with Him, which is something that we take for granted. We take this opportunity for granted because when we look at other religions, such as ancient Greek polytheism, we see that humans do not have an opportunity for a good everlasting afterlife, instead it is an afterlife of infinite regret and despair.



A public lecture delivered by Mr. John Lindsley at the Via House

The next book we read, the *Odyssey*, further developed many of the themes we saw in the *Iliad*, focusing now on principles of Greek piety. The mortals in the *Odyssey* follow specific rules and make specific actions toward the gods, such as obeying their commands, making sacrifices, and being hospitable to the poor and needy. These aspects of piety helped show how the ancient Greeks were right in understanding some of the goods that agree with the Christian perspective. The good pious actions that are shown in the *Odyssey* remind us of the natural law that God instilled in the world he created, and also remind us of how we ought to act towards God and others. Similar to how the *Iliad* portrayed the nature of the gods, the *Odyssey* reveals how their natures differ from the Triune God of Christianity.

Continuing with the *Odyssey*, a main principle of piety touched upon is the custom of *xenia*, the Greek word for hospitality. Xenia is a rule set forth by Zeus that states all strangers and wanderers are to be fed, housed, and treated with respect. Seeing Greek hospitality exemplified in the *Odyssey* reminds us of how we are to treat others, and that how we treat others has a direct affect on how our Lord will judge us. In Matthew 25: 40-42, Christ shows how our Lord will judge us, saying, “And the King will answer them, ‘Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brethren, you did it to me.’ Then he will say to those at his left hand, ‘Depart from me, you cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels; for I was hungry and you gave me no food, I was thirsty and you gave me no drink.’” This verse shows Christ expects us to treat others as himself, identifying himself as those in need, outlining a similar principle like *xenia* in the *Odyssey*. The Greeks’ observance of *xenia* is similar to Christ’s teachings in the sense that both principles demand that good will be done to those in need. The Greeks here show that they have some recognition of the natural moral goods that our Lord instilled in the hearts of all of us.

Our next book, *Nicomachean Ethics*, we discussed to a large extent the question, “What is happiness?” It was a simple question which was at first hard to answer. If you ask most people why they live, or what they live for, all answers will point back to them wanting to be happy. Aristotle would argue that happiness is both the common and highest good that all humans seek but not everyone agrees on what exactly *makes* them happy. For example, most people would agree that saving lives as a missionary is more fulfilling than binge-drinking and watching sports every day. This suggests that we all have a vague understanding of higher goods. But many people in modern society would say that you should follow whatever you *think*, or rather, whatever you *feel* makes you happy. This line of thought has poisoned the minds of many. People choose to live a life of temporary pleasure and they fail to realize that there are higher goods beyond their perceptions that can lead to a happier life. Understanding the futility of these short term pleasures can better motivate us to make sacrifices for future happiness.

It is true that there is a good that all actions strive towards, but not all actions lead us to happiness, and many actions keep us away from *the* good. Even a murderer murders because they thought at the time it was good for themselves in some sense. We all choose actions because we think they are good, at least in the moment. Aristotle would argue that we must strive towards the highest good, which are goods of the soul. Goods of the soul are associated with rational human activity and virtue, which surpass other goods because they are associated with our nature and contribute more to our overall well-being. He defines happiness as “rational activity of the soul in accordance with virtue.” Activity of the soul refers to what makes a human distinctly human, which is the ability to reason.



Seminar with Fr. Francisco at the end of year retreat

We can determine whether animals are good or bad based on what makes them distinctly flourish. For example, a good squirrel fulfills its nature by gathering acorns, leaping through trees, etc.. A bad squirrel fails at these things. It is easy to pinpoint the characteristics that make a squirrel good or bad. To be a good human is a trickier question because of the innumerable characteristics. Aristotle would say that humans distinctly have an intellect and the capacity for rational thought. Humans exercising their intellect are fully expressing what makes them distinctly human. Through our intellect we can come to know what is true and good, distinguishing good from bad by way of reasoning. Using our intellect by way of reason is most fully expressed when in accordance with virtue, a habit of the soul reflected in our actions and choices. This is because doing what is virtuous is doing what is true, good, and right. Aristotle stresses that we must exercise virtue and strive to know the ultimate truths of the universe by seeking God, which ultimately leads to happiness. Happiness is not something that can be found directly but can be achieved pursuing a life of virtue, which is the most pleasurable life.

Toward the end of *Ethics* Aristotle says, “what is appropriate by nature to each being is best and most pleasant for each, and so, for a human being, this is the life in accord with the intellect, if that most of all is a human being. Therefore this life is also the happiest.” Aristotle establishes here that the intellectual life is the happiest because it most fully expresses our human nature. The *Ethics* directly relates to our salvation as Christians because we must live virtuously to achieve union with God, which brings us eternal happiness.

Going over the *Illiad*, *Odyssey*, and *Nichomachean Ethics* was a major portion of our seminar content in the Spring. Along with these works, we also carefully read the gospel of John, focusing on understanding how God has revealed himself through scripture. The lessons I have learned from our seminars in Via have been extremely valuable in aiding my understanding of the nature of God, and have also helped me develop a clearer framework for living a life that strives towards heaven.

Work

On Tuesdays and Thursdays the Fellows engage in professional life by working in a career field of interest alongside a Catholic professional. Here, we develop a proper sense of what a good Catholic work culture looks like, as well as discern what profession we wish to pursue. This spring, I decided to work for St. Joseph’s Handyman which is a handyman company that provides service in fields such as maintenance, restoration, carpentry, remodeling, flooring, etc. St. Joseph’s Handyman’s mission is “We are handymen who strive for excellence and virtue, in order to better serve the community around the Acadiana area. Our work is a means by which we grow as disciples of Christ and share the Gospel to those we serve.”

Even though I do not plan on being a handyman, I chose to work at St. Joseph's because I was looking for a virtuous leadership team that could exemplify a healthy work culture centering their professional lives around Christ. The employees make promises to devote themselves to Catholic practices so that their work reflects the message of the Gospel. Three guys work full time and each of them are great virtuous men who have given me lasting examples of balancing being a follower of Christ, a husband, a father, and a professional. As handymen, we deal with many issues that range from fixing a leak in the roof to building a fence, and as a future homeowner, I desire to learn how to embrace new challenges and solve them on my own, and St. Joseph's has given me the tools to do so.

The employees, too, are devoted to providing for others (their families, co-workers, and clients), while still living a simple life that is centered around Christ. Observing this gave me clarity and reassurance of my own plan to become a physical therapist, and that you don't have to have a fancy faith-based job to be a good Christian; there can be much fruit to working in a normal profession while providing for your family.



Prayer

The "prayer" aspect of Via aims to develop the spiritual life of the Fellow by implementing structures into its daily, weekly, and monthly schedules. Each day the fellows spend one hour in the presence of the blessed sacrament, as well as attend Holy Mass. The cohort almost always attends these obligations together while maintaining timeliness, helping our itinerary run seamlessly. Being timely is not always easy because it begins on most days at 6:30am, but this expectation has helped me develop this good habit. In addition to prayer and daily Mass, we also pray night prayer at 9pm each night and then enter into silence till the following morning Mass. This structure requires us to be back at the house at the same time, promoting a solemn environment that invites reflection, study, and makes it easier to be rested for a full schedule the next day.

My prayer experience in Via has resulted in a more disciplined spiritual regimen. My prayer has been guided with the help of a spiritual director and two spiritual mentors who have helped me overcome various challenges such as facing perpetual dryness and distraction. Early on, my prayer was disordered; I would sit in the chapel for an hour and felt like I prayed about nothing. In response to this I would read to flood my prayer with material to meditate upon, but this led to me trying to incorporate too much into my holy hour. In spiritual direction I was advised to simplify my prayer life and to structure my holy hour. I continued to face dryness but I felt as if the Lord wanted me to persist through the struggle. By being intentional in my prayer despite the struggles, things began to greatly improve. Familiarizing myself with the practices of lectio divina, which is a style of prayer that focuses on meditating upon scripture, has helped bring more substance to my prayer. This is because Christ was revealing himself to me through scripture, giving me good lessons and practical takeaways.



The Via cohort in our daily holy hour

My time in the chapel also became an occasion for discernment, particularly of things such as relationships, future profession, and plan after Via Nova. Additionally, my meetings with formators provided wise, personal counsel that helped give me clarity on what to think and pray about, and I believe it has helped me better unite my desires to the Lord.

Along with prayer, participating in daily mass became increasingly spiritually beneficial for me. The more I attended mass, the more I began to understand how important receiving Jesus in the sacrament is. I often devoted myself to contemplating Christ's passion and sacrifice during the liturgy. I believe that the consistent participation in mass helped and healed me in so many ways. It has helped me be more repulsed by my sin, because the more I come to know Christ's love for us, the more it pains me to offend and turn away from him. Attending mass has also deepened my devotion to Christ in the Eucharist, through meditating on his incarnation, passion, and resurrection. This meditation during the liturgy helps me better perceive Christ's humility, divinity, and love for us.

A large portion of our spring was spent during the season of Lent. Prior to Lent, the Fellows agreed on a set of Lenten penances that we all were going to practice together. These penances were especially rigorous because we wanted to embrace the true spirit of Lent, which is depriving and detaching oneself of worldly goods and pleasures. This Lent was fruitful because the sacrifices I made such as no media usage and cold showers turned my mind away from distractions and I found it easier to think more about Christ and his sacrifice for us.

With Lent being accompanied by seminar readings on the *Nicomachean Ethics*, I spent more time reflecting on my habits and ways of thinking. This self-reflection has helped motivate me to adopt structures in my life outside of Via, because I believe these structures are essential in building virtues.



The beginning of the Easter Vigil Mass during our Triduum retreat

Communal Life

The communal life in Via is another aspect of the formative experience and has been especially helpful for growing in self-knowledge. Spending a great deal of time with the other Fellows has revealed to me some faults in my character. I found that the more time you spend with someone, the more of your true self is revealed. The communal life in Via tested me each day, presenting me with opportunities to grow in fraternal charity and self-sacrifice.

"Check-ins" were a major part of this in Via. In our bi-weekly men's check-ins, we examine our actions and share our self-assessments so that we can identify where we can grow in charity and become better housemates and Christians.

Each Monday we have "Street Walks," where we walk around our neighborhood, knocking on doors and praying for others. These "street walks" gave us an opportunity to bring Christ to our neighbors. One special encounter was with Prince, a UL student from Ghana. I first met Prince while knocking on doors, and he just happened to be walking out of his apartment. After briefly greeting him, he immediately invited us inside and we began to talk. After a very deep conversation, I invited him to one of our community events. Now, Prince has come to a couple of our events and has greatly appreciated our community. Introducing friends like Prince to Cajun culture and Catholic community has been a great joy.



Breakfast with the Via crew at the St. Julien House



Cajun dancing at the Via house

Another example of being present to the wider community happened while driving with the other Fellows in the snow. After talking to my friends, we decided to drive some street friends (who were the only ones outside in the 20 degree weather) to the homeless shelter for warmth. But when we got there it was completely full, with many people without shelter or food. We decided to shuttle people to the other shelter in Brown Park, and I had the opportunity to get to know them and hear their stories. Some I had spoken with had slept in the blizzard the night before. It was shocking to hear how many people had to endure such suffering. At the shelter, we got to converse and play games with the residents, and it was such a joyful experience. This is just one way that I never thought about serving the wider community until this spring. Experiences like these have motivated me to provide more help in the future to the less fortunate.

Communal life also consisted of weekly public events like poetry nights, jam nights, public talks, pilgrimages, presentations, and other communal gatherings. Early in Spring, the cohort went on a pilgrimage to New Orleans, where we visited Notre Dame Seminary for a requiem Mass as well as numerous other churches around New Orleans. Each Church we visited reflected a beauty and attention to detail rarely seen in modern churches. Modernism, which has been condemned as heresy by Pope Pius X, has drastically changed the traditional concept of beauty in churches and many Christians now believe that the beauty of a church distracts them from worship, rather than aiding it. Many also believe that churches should have minimalist and inexpensive designs so that more money can be spent on evangelization and helping the poor. These ideas however, miss the notion that beauty and God are one and the same, and that beauty draws us to God. Christ, who dwells physically in the tabernacle of every Catholic church, deserves to be glorified in a beautiful house of worship. Beauty in churches gives what is due to Christ, which are our firstfruits.



The National Votive Shrine of
Our Lady of Prompt Succor



St. Mary's Assumption Church in New Orleans



A requiem mass at Notre Dame seminary chapel

Even though New Orleans has many beautiful churches, the presence of Catholics in church has greatly diminished. Msgr. Nalty gave us a tour of the Basilica of St. Stephen, where he serves as pastor. Monsignor explained that due to poor church attendance and low income, many churches cannot support themselves, and many are being used for historical tours, pilgrimages, and weddings. Seeing the beautiful empty churches in New Orleans gave me a new perspective on how secularization has affected our culture.

In February, we began preparations for the Courir de Lundi Gras, a traditional Mardi Gras run at the Via house in Freetown by hosting various community events. These events included a Lundi Gras ball in St. Martinville, costume-making workshops, and Cajun chant practices for the runners. We also hosted a talk on Cajun Mardi Gras culture given by Dr. Barry Jean Ancelet, a man who some say is the leading expert on Cajun culture. Each of these events helped us and friends in the community develop a greater understanding of the spirit of Mardi Gras.



Human chariots at our Freetown Courir de Lundi Gras

On the morning of Lundi Gras, the runners attended a preparatory Mass, and following the Mass the run was commenced at the Via house with Fr. Jason Vidrine offering a French blessing for those participating. There were over thirty runners, four Capitaines, and a large group following the parade. After the commencement, we proceeded from home to home, begging for ingredients for a gumbo. A truck with Cajun music also followed the parade, keeping the atmosphere lively. This continued throughout the day, and we stopped to chase chickens and share meals at various local companies and houses who supported our efforts. After the run, we headed back to the Via House to enjoy the gumbo and dance to live Cajun music. This event was a highlight of the spring. Our efforts aimed to help revive the dying Cajun Mardi Gras culture in the Lafayette area while also showing that Mardi Gras doesn't have to be debaucherous.

In March, we hosted a Day of Recollection retreat with the Community of Jesus Crucified in St. Martinville. During this short day retreat, we heard talks from Fr. Michael Champagne CJC as well as a talk from Deacon John Paul, CJC. The conferences discussed the progression of the prayer life and taught us how to interpret and pray with Scripture.



The runners chanting and begging for gumbo ingredients



Friends at a Via lecture

Throughout the year, we also hosted public lectures given by various speakers, including our tutor John Lindsley, Via director Luke Ungarino, Dr. Cory Hayes, Deacon Adam Conque, and Fr. Aaron Williams. These talks addressed topics such as ancient literature and history, modern problems of education, potential pitfalls of Catholic culture and moral culpability. We also held occasional community events that involved live Cajun music and dancing. During the spring, we went Irish roving in the downtown Lafayette area. As a group, we practiced several Irish chants and songs and then proceeded to various establishments throughout the night to celebrate St. Patrick and honor old Catholic traditions of festivity.

Spring Pilgrimage and Retreats

Later in the spring, the Fellows went on a ten-day pilgrimage to Krakow, Poland and Vienna, Austria. This pilgrimage was the focal point of the spring and was aimed at more deeply exploring Catholic culture in two of the most Catholic cities in the world. In preparation for the trip, we studied these Catholic cultures and learned specifically about the Catholic monarchies that heavily influenced the region's culture and history. We attended daily Mass with our chaplain Fr. Francisco Nahoe, OFM Conv., a Franciscan friar from California who accompanied us and led seminars that focused on the topic of scriptural exegesis, which closely examines and interprets Scripture using historical and literary contexts. Fr. Francisco and I spent much time together, and he helped me analyze both Scripture and church architecture. Mr. Charles A. Coulombe, a Catholic author, historian, and expert on European Catholic history, also accompanied us on part of our pilgrimage. Much of our lectures and tours with Mr. Coulombe centered around the Habsburgs, the most influential and powerful European royal family in history.



The Via cohort walking the streets of Vienna with Mr. Charles Coulombe

In Vienna, we were fortunate to stay at a Franciscan Friary as well as Stift Heiligenkreuz Monastery, the oldest continuously running Cistercian monastery in the world. We visited several churches, learning about their history and architecture, and saw major buildings such as Stephansdom (St. Stephen's Cathedral), Schönbrunn Palace, and Melk Abbey.

In Kraków, Poland, we toured many churches, with my favorite being St. Mary's Basilica. We stayed in the heart of Krakow and had the privilege to pray and attend Mass at various churches. We attended two ensembles that played various classical pieces by artists like Mozart, an Austrian native, and Frédéric Chopin, a Polish native. We visited Auschwitz, the Jewish district, the Wieliczka Salt Mine, the St. John Paul II National Shrine, and the National Shrine of the Divine Mercy. At the Divine Mercy Shrine, we venerated the original Divine Mercy image at St. Faustina's convent. We also took a bus to Jasna Góra Monastery to see the Icon of Our Lady of Czestochowa, which is a famous icon said to be written by St. Luke and made from the Holy Family's table. Throughout the ages, the icon has passed from place to place with many attempts to destroy it. The icon has been attributed to over 1000 miracles, such as saving the monastery from the Swedish invasion in 1655, as well as healing injuries miraculously.



Banquet and dance hall at Schönbrunn Palace



The famous icon of Our Lady of Czestochowa



Vienna City Hall



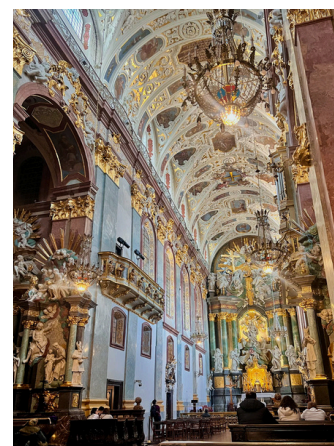
St. Mary's Basilica in Kraków, Poland



The main church at Melk Abbey



St. Stephen's Cathedral in Vienna



The Church of St. Anne in Kraków

This year's European pilgrimage gave me deep insight into the remnants of predominant Catholic culture and history. Learning about the history of the Habsburgs and the Catholic heritage of Austria and Poland revealed the previous dominance of Christian ideals within Western society. But like most of the world, Krakow, and especially Vienna, have become secularized shells of what they once were, showing how much worse society is without Christ. The rapid dechristianization of the world has turned the most beautiful churches into museums for Instagram pictures and sightseeing tours. While this tourism isn't bad, it seems as if touring these churches is the main reason they are open, rather than for prayer, sacrifice, and worship.

One of my favorite moments of the trip was the last day where we toured churches and monasteries around the Vienna countryside. Before we hit the road, we attended Mass at the monastery where we stayed. After Mass, we explored as much of the monastery as we could using a digital audio tour guide, which gave us insight into the rich history of the monastery. After departing from the monastery, we toured a Benedictine monastery called Melk Abbey. This monastery showed how important the monastic tradition was in early Western Europe. It sat on top of a large plateau overlooking a small town, serving as the centerpiece of the beautiful landscape.



The Via cohort at the Cistercian Abbey of Heiligenkreuz

We then visited a church attached to a convent in the countryside town of Maria Taferl. Visiting this quiet town and church was the highlight of my trip because it brought me peace amidst the busyness of the journey. The town, which has fewer than one thousand people, is a major pilgrimage site and home to the Basilika Maria Taferl. Its near-complete silence immediately struck me as I explored. Walking around the town and observing its intricate beauty felt very prayerful. Everything seemed to slow down, and I was able to relish the present moment, which was difficult during a trip filled with so many activities. It seemed to have a charm and tranquility that I haven't often experienced in America.

Upon our return to the U.S, the Fellows attended a Triduum retreat at Grand Coteau retreat center. This retreat was led by Archbishop Prendergast SJ of Ontario, Canada, and focused on solemn liturgy, Christ's Passion, prayer, and fasting. The retreat was another opportunity to disconnect from technology and outside distractions, helping us prepare for the Resurrection of Christ on Easter.

We returned to Grand Coteau's retreat center for our end of the year spring retreat in May. On this five-day silent retreat, the Fellows and I had spiritual direction, attended mass, prayed, read, and chanted the liturgy of the hours. Much of my time was spent trying to understand and practice the contemplative life. I was also able to reflect on my time in Via, reflecting on the graces that I have been blessed with. This retreat was a great way to end my time in Via.

My time in Via has profoundly shaped my intellectual, professional, and spiritual growth. Through our seminars and presentations, I have learned to understand and analyze what is presented to me in a deeper way—whether through reading or conversation with others. My work experience provided valuable insight into Catholic work culture and how one's professional life can be harmonized with family life. Prayer, daily Mass, and other devotional practices taught me to embrace the spiritual life in a more complete and intentional way.

This year would not have been possible without the support and encouragement of so many generous people. I could not have walked this path alone. The prayers, financial support, sacrifices, and charity of others made this opportunity—one I will cherish forever—possible. I am deeply grateful to all who have helped me along this journey: my supporters, spiritual intercessors, family, friends, peers, the entire Via community, and especially Via Director Luke Ungarino and Via Tutor John Lindsley.

To Luke—thank you for your intentionality and selflessness. I will forever be indebted to the time and effort you poured into us.

To Mr. John—thank you for your commitment to forming us as disciples of Christ. Your example, counsel, and insights have given me invaluable takeaways.

To my supporters—your generosity not only enabled me to have this formative experience but also reminded me that I am not alone in my mission as a disciple.

I would also like to thank my intercessors, family, friends, peers, and all who have been part of our community in some way. Your prayers, selflessness, love, joy, and witness to Christ have borne great fruit in my life. The Lord has blessed me abundantly and revealed Himself to me through each of you. Thank you, once again, for your sacrifice and love. As I move forward, I humbly ask for your prayers—for me, for the other Fellows, and for the future cohorts of Via. If there is ever any way I can pray for you, please don't hesitate to let me know.

May God bless you,

Channing Patin



The Basilika Maria Taferl



The crew at the Triduum retreat in Grand Coteau